

PROFILE | PRAGYA SINGH THAKUR

The Avenging Angel

The ochre-robed young firebrand has emerged out of virtual obscurity to become the charismatic spearhead of a new form of Hindu militancy: deadly violence based on an eye for an eye. Pragya Singh Thakur, 36, is almost a clone of a Ritambhara or an Uma Bharati at the peak of the Ram Janmabhoomi movement of the 1990s but while the worst that the previous sadhvis of the saffron camp were accused of was arousing religious passions through their spirited rhetoric, Sadhvi Poornachetanand Giri is being accused of a much deadlier sin—involvement in the Malegaon bomb blasts of September 29, 2008. She was picked up by the Mumbai ATS from her father Chandrapal Singh Thakur's home in Surat district in Gujarat after investigations found that the explosive-strapped LML bike once belonged to her. Although he claims that she had bought the bike in 2003 but sold it four years ago, it was still registered in her name at Surat RTO office when the Malegaon blasts happened.

The third child in a brood of five, she joined the ABVP in the early 1990s. Her father left for Surat in early 2000 even as Thakur, a PG in History from Lahar, was charting out a course of her own. She rose to the post of state organising secretary of ABVP in 1996 before quitting the organisation.

Her association with Vande Matram Jan Kalyan Samiti is being investigated by the Mumbai ATS. Meanwhile, she was also a member of Rashtrawadi Sena, another loose-knit saffron organisation. She has been active in Madhya Pradesh's Malwa region, which is a strong Hindutva citadel. Thakur stayed in Jabalpur for a while where she still owns a house that was raided by the police. With her boy-cut hairstyle and clean-cut good looks, the Sadhvi had also had many suitors over the years. During her college days, a young IPS officer went to her father seeking her hand in marriage. But the Sadhvi refused, stating she was ordained for higher pursuits in life. Another ABVP leader who has now come to occupy an important post in the BJP organisation was also believed to have been taken in by her beauty and youthful charm, only to be rejected. At the Allahabad Kumbh in 2007, she chose her destiny to be a Sadhvi. Some reports suggest that the Sadhvi had got in touch with two ex-servicemen who are the latest to have been detained by the Mumbai ATS from Pune at a religious discourse in Pune last year. The idea was to acquire technical knowhow of putting together bombs and ways to get the deadly ingredients that resulted in the Malegaon blasts.

ANIL TIWARI



FIREBRAND: Thakur (centre) with Mayaram Jaiswani (right) of Abhinav Bharat

and perhaps, even supply, of explosives. "Organising bomb blasts shows an intent and determination to carry out planned attacks against Muslims. This is reverse terrorism. The Hindu outfits are on the verge of being declared terrorist organisations," said a senior intelligence official. In fact, the exercise to ban some of the right-wing organisations, including the Bajrang Dal and Durga Vahini among others, is already underway. "The dossiers are being prepared. Evidence is being collected from all over the country about the attacks they have been involved in. When we have enough, the Government will put it before the Cabinet, seeking a ban. The effort is to nip it before it becomes a burning communal fire," the official said.

The more daunting prospect lies in the political dimensions of the development, especially with crucial general elections approaching and parties eying votebanks. While the Congress was quick to latch on to the issue of Hindu terrorism, the BJP first floundered and then decided to disown the Sadhvi. The BJP again found itself trapped in the age-old dilemma—whether to go with political correctness or stick by its political character. That indecisiveness has allowed the Congress to attack. Says party spokesman Abhishek Singhvi: "The blasts were more terrifying than a general terror act because they involve and implicate almost a mainstream party, the BJP." BJP's prime ministerial hopeful L.K. Advani and senior leader Yashwant Sinha took exception to the term Hindu terrorism and said that the Sadhvi had quit ABVP in 1997 and was not related to the party in any way. Sinha added that the law should take its course and proceed against the Sadhvi if indeed she was proven guilty of direct involvement in the Malegaon blasts.

The Sangh cadres have not take the attitude of senior BJP